Growth Prescription

CareerForge Day 7 — Engineering Defence Board

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This is not motivational writing. It is a practical engineering improvement plan based on evidence from this week.

Primary Growth Area

What capability needs the most improvement? AI trust judgment — specifically the habit of evaluating every AI recommendation with a failure-sequence test before acting on it, not after discovering a problem downstream.

Evidence from the challenge:

• Day 5: The Redis atomic decrement plan used real commands, real Redis terminology, and looked authoritative. I had to reconstruct the failure path (restart resets counter → A and C both charged for same unit → Postgres never updated) by working backwards. That reconstruction should have been my first move.

• Day 4: The AI recommended a full override management module for a two-week pilot. I rejected it — but after reading through the full spec. The filter 'does this match the scope and timeline?' should activate before engaging with implementation detail.

Behavior To Change

What habit caused the gap? Treating AI output as a starting point to accept — and then fix if something goes wrong — rather than as a hypothesis to stress-test before acceptance.

What habit should replace it? For every AI recommendation, ask one question first: 'What is the failure sequence if this is wrong?' If I cannot answer that in two sentences, I do not have enough understanding to accept or reject the recommendation yet. Stop and find the answer before proceeding.

30-Day Practice Plan

Week	Practice Focus	Concrete Action	Proof You Did It
Week 1	Failure-sequence testing on AI suggestions	For every AI code suggestion or architecture recommendation received, write the failure sequence in 2 sentences before accepting it. Do this before reading any implementation detail.	Log of 5 AI suggestions evaluated this way — accepted, modified, or blocked — with a one-line reason for each decision.
Week 2	End-to-end workflow verification before declaring readiness	Before calling any feature done or ready, write the critical workflow in one sentence and run it fully — not just the component that was changed.	Screenshot or terminal log of the full workflow run for each feature completed this week.
Week 3	Premise questioning before investigation	When given a bug report or task description, write down 'What assumption am I accepting here?' before touching any code or log file.	One documented assumption challenge per debugging task — even if the assumption turned out to be correct.
Week 4	Combined habits under time pressure	Simulate a time-limited debugging or design decision. Apply all three habits simultaneously: declare workflow, question premise, test AI output for failure sequence.	One written incident-style summary of a real or practice scenario where all three habits were applied and the outcome noted.

AI Discipline Plan

How I will use AI without outsourcing judgment:

• Use AI to generate options, not decisions. Ask it to list failure modes, edge cases, or alternative approaches — then evaluate each against the specific context the AI does not have.

- Never forward an AI recommendation without being able to explain the failure sequence if it is wrong. If I cannot explain it, I have not evaluated it — I have forwarded it.
- When AI output matches what I expected, treat that as a reason to be more skeptical — not less. The Day 5 Redis plan was dangerous partly because it sounded correct.

Final Growth Commitment

For the next 30 days: every time I receive an AI suggestion or a directive from a founder or authority figure, I will write one sentence — 'What breaks if this is wrong?' — before I act on it. Not after. This single habit covers premise questioning, end-to-end verification, and AI judgment simultaneously. I will track it in a daily log and review it weekly.